

■ By Priya Sahgal

It is certainly not any literary prize for non-fiction that L.K. Advani is after. The new, octogenarian bestselling author in town has his gaze fixed on a more coveted trophy. The many star-studded launches of his massive memoirs, *My Country, My Life*, did not even pretend to be literary events, anyway. They were shows of strength where a potential prime minister was at his Dale Carnegie best: winning hard-to-win friends and influencing those hard-to-please people. Perhaps the first Indian politician after Jawaharlal Nehru to write his autobiography at the peak of his career, Advani, in the words of his old comrade in arms, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who has written the foreword, is "an outstanding leader whose best is yet to come." Before that, he has a lot to explain. This 942-page clarification, he hopes, will add the much needed statesman-like aura to his leadership qualities. He denies the timing, but the fact that he chose to clear the air so soon after being declared BJP's prime ministerial candidate is no coincidence.

To market Brand Advani on the eve of the general elections, just one book launch won't do. In five-city book launches, Page One political power would rub shoulders with Page Three glamour. And after all, Advani knows a thing or two about marketing strategy. At a time when his political contemporaries went on *padyatras* (walkathons), he climbed on a rath and created a whole new image for himself as the warrior-in-chief of the right. And what better way to pitch for a Ram temple—and a BJP-led government in Delhi—than from atop a chariot?

The Delhi launch of his memoirs had most of the NDA and BJP chief ministers in attendance, not to mention some friends from across the political divide such as Sharad Pawar, Praful Patel and Om Prakash Chautala while Mumbai brought in the Big B of Bollywood, Amitabh Bachchan himself. The Congress, though invited, decided to boycott the release of a book that was critical of its leader. No matter. Still, Advani included both Sonia and Manmohan Singh (whom he refers to as India's "weakest prime minister") in his goodwill tour as he embarked on

TURNING A NEW PAGE

The publication of his memoirs has become an occasion for marketing a kinder, gentler leader eager to win more friends and influence even political foes.



"I FEEL A BIT GUILTY ABOUT REPEATEDLY USING

a door-to-door promotion of his book, personally handing out copies to both Sonia and Manmohan. The Congress saw it as a desperate attempt to fashion himself on a Vajpayeesque mould. "I am glad he went to 10 Janpath. I always felt that even after having stayed so long with Atalji, Advani did not show Atalji's statesmanship," mocked Congress General Secretary Digvijay Singh.

The book has ensured that the focus is firmly on Advani and not BJP. According to his publisher, the book has already sold its first print order of

50,000 copies within a week. At a book signing function in Mumbai, Advani was mobbed by college students. This cult of personality politics is normally reserved for the Congress. Within BJP, it was only Vajpayee who was larger than the party. A party that eschewed personality politics had marketed him as the "Man India Awaits". But now, with the launch of his personal manifesto, Advani has made himself the dominant issue. The entire publicity for the book release is being handled by his family and not the party. Advani's wife,